

Sports Activities - Comparison & Discussion Starter

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. The comparison, at a glance

	Horse riding	Tennis	Basketball (core)	Basketball (extension)
Source	Horse & Hound	LTA (British governing body)	Young Ballerz Basketball	The Athletic
Accent	British	Northern British	British (young presenter)	British-sounding, despite American source
Sport's "home" culture	British	British	British club context	Entirely American (NBA)
Individual or team	Individual	Individual (or doubles)	Team	Team
What the video actually does	Shows technique, step by step	Coaches a real skill live	A child explains rules	Explains tactical roles/positions
Type of language	Direct commands (walk on, heels down)	Direct commands + technique tips	Definitions of rules	Analysis, comparison, description
Register focus	Imperative vs diplomatic	Imperative vs diplomatic	Rule vocabulary	Descriptive/ analytical vocabulary

2. Discussion questions

Use as many or as few as fit the time you have – roughly ordered from easiest to most open-ended.

1. **Command vs explanation.** In horse riding and tennis, the coach speaks *to you* and expects immediate action ("heels down," "watch the ball"). In the basketball videos, nobody gives you a direct command – they explain rules or describe roles. Which kind

of English is easier for you to understand? Which is more useful for actually playing a sport?

2. **Individual vs team.** Horse riding and tennis are things you do largely on your own, even with a coach shouting instructions. Basketball needs you to understand your teammates' roles, not just your own actions. Does that change what kind of vocabulary matters most in each sport?
 3. **Accent and identity.** Every video so far has sounded British, even the one about an entirely American sport, made by an American company. Does the accent you hear change how you think about a sport's "nationality"? Would the basketball extension video feel different to you with an American voice instead?
 4. **Which sport is more "British," which is more "American"?** Horse riding and tennis (especially Wimbledon) have a strong association with Britain; basketball is dominated by American culture (the NBA). Do you agree? What about football/soccer, or cricket – where would you place them, and why?
 5. **Learning style.** Which of the three sports did you find easiest to follow in English, and why? Was it the accent, the speed, the vocabulary, or the type of content (commands vs explanation)?
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3. Optional extension

If the group has energy for it, this could become a short written or spoken debate: "*Is it more useful to learn sport in English through direct commands (like a real lesson) or through explanation (like a video essay)?*" Split into two sides, each defending one approach, using specific examples from the four videos as evidence.

4. Written exercises (10 min)

A. Comparative sentences - fill in the blank

Word bank: *more than* · *less than* · *both* · *neither* · *whereas* · *while*

1. Basketball needs teamwork _____ horse riding and tennis are mostly individual.
2. __ **tennis** _____ horse riding use direct imperative commands.
3. The basketball videos explain _____ they give commands.
4. Horse riding uses _____ vocabulary than basketball's rule-based videos.
5. _____ horse riding nor tennis is a team sport.

B. Rewrite the register

Rewrite each command from the imperative register (from the star tables in horse riding/tennis/basketball) into the diplomatic register, or vice versa.

1. "Watch the ball." _____

2. "Could you get back and help on defense?" _____

3. "Heels down." _____

C. Short written comparison

Write 5–6 sentences comparing two of the three sports (your choice), using at least 3 words from the comparative word bank above.

A natural bridge, if you want one, back to the Cambridge vs Oxford / debate format you've used before – same skill (defending a position with evidence), new topic.

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About this activity

For B1-B2 – a wrap-up piece once horse riding, tennis, and basketball have all been covered ~15–20 min discussion

A. Comparative sentences - fill in the blank

1. 1. whereas/while 2. Both / and 3. rather than 4. more direct 5. Neither

B. Rewrite the register

1. 1. Could you keep your eyes on the ball, please? 2. Get back on defense. 3. Would you mind putting your heels down?